Lessons Not Learnt

Since the NTA took over NEET-UG in 2019, there have been several attempts to compromise the exam's integrity. In 2021, the agency cancelled the results of 15 candidates for unfair practices. In 2022, the CBI busted an impersonation racket of "solvers" allegedly appearing for candidates. In 2025, it booked a person accused of impersonating a candidate in NEET-UG 2023. In 2024, a scandal erupted on three fronts. In Hazaribagh, the CBI found that one person had accessed the paper with the help of the principal and vice-principal of a school that was designated exam centre, and brokers later charged 144 aspirants Rs 30–50 lakh each. In Godhra, 27 candidates were allegedly asked to leave OMR (optical mark recognition) sheets blank so that insiders could fill them later. The price? Rs 10 lakh per candidate. The results triggered national outrage after 67 candidates, several from the same centre, scored a perfect 720, following the NTA's award of "grace marks" to 1,563 students. The grace marks were later withdrawn, but a Supreme Court bench led by then Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud refused to cancel the exam, holding that the leak was localised and that there was no evidence of a "systemic" nationwide breach. A limited re-test was ordered instead, and a correction to a disputed Physics question brought the number of perfect scorers down from 67 to 17.

But the malaise persists. On May 25, hearing two petitions, the apex court said the NTA had failed to learn from the 2024 crisis. That breach had triggered two reform processes: the first a seven-member high-level committee of experts chaired by former ISRO chairman K. Radhakrishnan, set up by the education ministry in June 2024 to overhaul the end-to-end exam process and the NTA itself. The second was the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, chaired by Digvijaya Singh, whose Report 371, tabled in December 2025, said the NTA's conduct of exams in 2024 "has not inspired much confidence". Now, the Federation of All India Medical Association has sought the agency's "replacement or fundamental restructuring". Unlike the constitutional UPSC (Union Public Service Commission) or the statutory Staff Selection Commission, the NTA was founded under the Societies Registration Act, 1860. The United Doctors Front has asked that it be dissolved in its present form and rebuilt as a statutory body created by Parliament, answerable to it and subject to CAG (Comptroller and Auditor General) audits and committee scrutiny. These doctors describe the 2026 leak as part of a "recurring, systemic and catastrophic failure", arguing that "cosmetic administrative tweaks" and committees such as the Radhakrishnan panel cannot fix it without a legislative overhaul. They have also sought digital locking of question papers and a complete shift to computer-based testing (CBT) to eliminate the risks of physical custody. Pradhan has already announced that NEET will move to CBT mode from next year.

The court issued a notice to the Union government, the education ministry, the NTA and the CBI, and gave the agency three days to file an affidavit detailing what it had actually done to implement those recommendations. Radhakrishnan himself was directed to file a separate affidavit on whether his panel's recommendations had been followed.



"The NTA was meant to be a very lean organisation... But in a pen-and-paper exam, you need some 10,000 people to run it. So, the NTA depends on outsourcing"

— R. Subrahmanyam, Former secretary, Department of Higher Education

The Untidiness of NEET

NEET is not the only NTA exam to run into trouble. But it is the only one that has been discredited repeatedly. Other high-stakes tests—Joint Entrance Examination for IITs (IIT-JEE), Common University Entrance Test (CUET), the UPSC civil services—do not see this frequency of full-blown leaks. Of course, they also draw far fewer candi-

NEET VERSUS JEE AND GAOKAO

China's Gaokao, like NEET-UG, is also conducted in pen-and-paper mode and handles six times more candidates, yet it rarely faces any major disruption

Objective	
Conducted by	
No. of candidates	
Stages	
Question paper security	
Test mode	
Vendor management	
Vulnerability to compromise	